Mars and Jupiter Are About to Meet in the Sky

From: Space.com Mined: 2026-11-14 3 min read

Look up on the night of November 15-16, and you will see two planets putting on a show. Mars and Jupiter will look very close together in the stars called Leo. They will not be this close again until July 2029.

The two planets will rise in the east around midnight. Mars will shine red, and Jupiter will shine bright next to it. The blue-white star **Regulus** will glow below them.

It is a trick of how we see things. Mars and Jupiter are really more than 368 million miles apart. They only look close because they line up from Earth.

Astronomers call this meeting an **appulse**. It happens about once every two to two and a half years, when Mars catches up to Jupiter.

Both Mars and Jupiter are "**superior planets**." That means they **orbit** farther from the sun than Earth does. Through a **telescope**, they always look full and round.

A six-inch **telescope** shows how different the two worlds are. Jupiter has giant bands of cloud. Mars looks red, with dark patches of rock.

Word Treasure

appulse -- When two planets look very close together in the sky.
superior planets -- Planets that orbit farther from the sun than Earth does.
orbit -- The path a planet follows around the sun.
telescope -- A tool that makes faraway things in the sky look bigger.
Regulus -- A bright blue-white star.

Background you need

Planets are big round worlds that travel around the sun.

Mars and Jupiter are two planets you can see in the night sky.

Sometimes they line up from Earth and look close together, even though they are very far apart.

Break it down

WHO: Mars, Jupiter, and the people watching them
WHAT: Two planets will look very close together in the night sky
WHERE: In the stars called Leo, in the east
WHY: The planets line up from Earth, so they look close even though they are far apart

Why it matters

You can step outside on a clear night and see two planets with your own eyes, which makes the solar system feel real and close.

Test what you remember

1. When can you see Mars and Jupiter close together?

- (A) On the night of November 15-16
- (B) On Christmas Day
- (C) On January 1
- (D) On July 4

2. In which stars will they appear?

- (A) Cassiopeia
- (B) Ursa Major
- (C) Leo
- (D) Orion

3. How far apart are Mars and Jupiter really?

- (A) 368 miles
- (B) 368 billion miles
- (C) 368 thousand miles
- (D) More than 368 million miles

4. What is this meeting called?

- (A) An eclipse
- (B) A meteor
- (C) A comet
- (D) An appulse

5. What are Mars and Jupiter called because they orbit farther from the sun than Earth?

- (A) Dwarf planets
- (B) Moons
- (C) Superior planets
- (D) Stars

6. What does Mars look like through a telescope?

- (A) Black, with rings
- (B) Red, with dark patches of rock
- (C) Green, with rivers
- (D) Blue, with white clouds

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):